

Handout - *Fiction, Myth, and Reality* Parts 1 & 2

The Problem and the Proposed Solution

The **central problem** Salmon begins with is one of the oldest and hardest puzzles in philosophy of language and metaphysics: **how can a sentence with a non-referring name be true?** The paradigm case is:

“Sherlock Holmes is nonexistent.” (p. 49)

This seems true when said about reality. But it also seems paradoxical. The sentence appears to be *about* Sherlock Holmes, and yet to say that Sherlock Holmes does not exist is precisely to deny that there is any such thing for the name to refer to. So how can the sentence manage to express a truth at all? Salmon treats this as the problem of **true singular negative existentials**: statements of the form “a does not exist,” where the name in subject position apparently fails to designate anything (pp. 49–50).

Salmon’s approach in this stretch of the paper is mainly *critical and diagnostic*: he argues that the most influential available strategies—Russellian description theory, Fregean sense-based accounts, and Kripke’s treatment of fiction and myth—each illuminate the issue but ultimately fail to solve the deepest form of the problem. The upshot is that the problem is more stubborn than these theories suggest, especially for a **Millian** or **direct-reference** view of names (pp. 54–55, 62–63).

I. The Classical Puzzle: Nondesignating Names and Negative Existentials

Salmon opens with the puzzle in its starkest form. Sentences such as:

- “Sherlock Holmes is nonexistent”
- “Santa Claus isn’t real”
- “There is no such intra-Mercurial planet as Vulcan”

all seem perfectly intelligible and often true, yet they involve **nondesignating names**—names that apparently do not refer to anything real (p. 49).

The puzzle is this: a sentence of the form “**a is nonexistent**” seems to both:

- presuppose that there is an *a* to be talked about, and

- deny that there is any such thing.

That is the source of the contradiction-like pressure already noted by G. E. Moore: to say of something that it is not, one seems first to need that very thing to be there for predication (pp. 49–50).

Russell's Strategy

Salmon first reviews **Russell's theory of descriptions**. Russell tries to avoid commitment to any mysterious nonentities by treating names like "Sherlock Holmes" as abbreviations for descriptions, e.g. *the uniquely Holmesesque individual* (pp. 50–51).

Then:

- "Sherlock Holmes used cocaine" becomes roughly: **Something uniquely Holmesesque used cocaine.**
- "Sherlock Holmes did not use cocaine" has two scope readings:
 - **wide scope**: something uniquely Holmesesque did not use cocaine
 - **narrow scope**: nothing uniquely Holmesesque used cocaine (p. 50)

Likewise:

- "Sherlock Holmes exists" becomes: **Something is uniquely Holmesesque**
- "Sherlock Holmes does not exist" becomes, on the reading Russell should prefer: **Nothing is uniquely Holmesesque** (p. 51)

This elegantly avoids saying of an object that it lacks existence. Instead, the existential claim is analyzed quantificationally.

Why This Matters

Russell's account captures an important intuition: the truth of "Sherlock Holmes does not exist" need not require any entity named Sherlock Holmes. The sentence can instead amount to saying that **nothing answers to the relevant description** (p. 51).

But Salmon is not satisfied, because this maneuver is unavailable to anyone who thinks ordinary proper names are not disguised descriptions.

Frege's Strategy: Sense, Reference, and Semantic Ascent

Salmon next considers **Frege**. Frege's theory allows a sentence containing a non-referring name to still have a **sense** (*Sinn*), even if it lacks a reference (*Bedeutung*) (p. 51). That seems

promising. But Frege's own extensional principles threaten to make existential statements involving empty names neither true nor false.

To solve this, perhaps sentences like:

- "Sherlock Holmes exists"
- "Sherlock Holmes does not exist"

should be understood in a kind of **semantic ascent**: they are really about the *name* "Sherlock Holmes," not directly about Holmes. So "Sherlock Holmes does not exist" comes out roughly as:

"'Sherlock Holmes' designates nothing [in English]." (pp. 51–52)

This preserves the truth conditions Frege wants while avoiding direct reference to a nonexistent object.

Salmon's Objection

Salmon argues that this gets at something **pragmatically conveyed**, but not what is **semantically encoded** (p. 52). The sentence "Sherlock Holmes does not exist" is not ordinarily about an English expression. Alonzo Church's translation argument makes this vivid: the original sentence and its semantic-ascent paraphrase translate differently and mean different things in another language (pp. 52–53).

So semantic ascent is not the right account of what the sentence literally means.

Intensional Ascent and the Direct-Reference Problem

Salmon then examines a more sophisticated Fregean move: **intensional ascent**. Instead of talking about the *word* "Sherlock Holmes," this view says existential discourse concerns the **sense** associated with the name. Thus:

- "Sherlock Holmes exists" means something like: the concept associated with *Sherlock Holmes* is a concept of something.
- "Sherlock Holmes does not exist" means: that concept is not a concept of anything (pp. 53–54)

This is more subtle than semantic ascent and avoids some earlier problems. Still, Salmon stresses that it is not available to a **Millian**. On Millianism, a proper name's semantic contribution is just its bearer. If there is no bearer, there is no such descriptive or Fregean content to exploit (pp. 54–55).

This is a crucial turning point in the handout:

For a direct-reference theorist, the problem cannot be solved by smuggling in descriptions, senses, or conceptual content. If “Sherlock Holmes” is genuinely empty, then how can a sentence containing it express a truth at all? (pp. 54–55)

Salmon aligns himself with the commonsense view that “Sherlock Holmes does not exist” is true, and indeed necessarily true, since Holmes is not even a merely possible individual (pp. 55–57).

II. Kripke and van Inwagen: Fictional Characters as Real Abstract Artifacts

The next major move is to discuss **Kripke** and **van Inwagen**, who argue that fictional characters are in some sense **real entities**—not flesh-and-blood people, but **abstract artifacts** created by authors (pp. 57–58).

So:

- Sherlock Holmes is not a real detective,
- but he may nonetheless exist as a **fictional character**,
- just as the Holmes stories exist as abstract cultural artifacts.

This explains truths like: Conan Doyle created Holmes, Holmes is more famous than many real people, Holmes was inspired by certain real persons, and so on (pp. 57–58).

Two Uses of “Sherlock Holmes”

Kripke’s key distinction is between two uses of the name:

- **Holmes 1**: the pretend name used *within the fiction* for a supposed man
- **Holmes 2**: the genuine metalinguistic/metafictional name used *outside the fiction* for the fictional character itself (pp. 59–60)

This is extremely powerful. It lets Kripke explain why:

- “According to the stories, Sherlock Holmes used cocaine” is true.
- “Sherlock Holmes used cocaine” may be true in an extended *truth-in-fiction* sense.
- Yet literally, no abstract artifact uses cocaine (pp. 60–61).

Likewise for myth:

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- **Vulcan 1** = the supposed planet
 - **Vulcan 2** = the mythically generated abstract artifact (pp. 62–63)

This distinction helps make sense of a great deal of our discourse about fiction and myth.

III. Why Kripke Still Does Not Solve the Core Problem

Salmon thinks Kripke's theory is brilliant but still insufficient. The reason is that the real problem concerns **Holmes 1**, the thoroughly nondesignating name. It is Holmes 1—not Holmes 2—who “literally does not exist” (p. 61).

Kripke proposes that saying “Holmes 1 does not exist” is really like saying:

There is no true proposition that Holmes 1 exists. (p. 62)

This is meant as a cautious speech act: perhaps there is no such proposition at all, because the name fails to refer.

But Salmon argues this does not solve the problem—it merely **pushes it back a level**. For now the problematic name appears inside a propositional clause:

- *the proposition that Holmes 1 exists*

If “Holmes 1” is thoroughly nondesignating, then why is *that* propositional term any less problematic? The account generates an **infinite regress**: each attempted analysis reintroduces the same difficulty in a more intensional setting (pp. 62–63).

So the section ends with a negative but philosophically important conclusion:

Kripke's intensional ascent does not finally explain how a true negative existential with a genuinely empty name is possible.
